STUDENT HANDOUT

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Spotting Propaganda

Grades 5–8 · Social Studies

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Propaganda through history. From ancient Rome to modern social media, those in power have used images to shape public opinion. Understanding propaganda techniques helps you recognize when someone is trying to manipulate you — and make your own informed decisions.

01 PART 1 — The Six Techniques

Bandwagon	Appeals to desire to belong; "everyone is doing it"
Fear	Creates anxiety about consequences; threatens harm
Name-Calling	Uses negative labels to create prejudice against enemies
Glittering Generalities	Vague positive words (freedom, honor) without substance
Transfer	Connects cause to respected symbols (flags, religion, family)
Testimonial	Uses trusted figures to endorse message

02 PART 2 — Analyze Two Propaganda Images

	IMAGE 1	IMAGE 2
Time period/country		
Technique(s) used		
Intended emotion		
Desired action		

PART 3

03 Think Deeper

Photo manipulation vs. posters: The Soviet government erased people from photographs after they were executed. Why is altering a photograph more dangerous than creating an obviously persuasive poster?

PART 4

04 Compare the Two Images

What do both images have in common?

What's different about how they try to persuade?

Which do you think was more effective? Why?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Spirit photography was propaganda that exploited grief. The stereoscope's "realistic" 3D images made Victorians trust visual "evidence."

How does our trust in realistic images make us more vulnerable to manipulation today?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Challenge: Find an advertisement or political image online. Identify which propaganda technique(s) it uses and discuss: Is this manipulation harmful or harmless?